

Your First 30 Days in Canada

A step-by-step checklist — organized by week so nothing falls through the cracks.

How to use: Work through tasks in order — Week 1 unlocks everything else. Tick each box as you complete it.

WEEK 1 · DAYS 1–7

Identity & The Essentials

Apply for your SIN (Social Insurance Number)

Service Canada in person. Bring passport + immigration docs.
Free and same-day.

Get a Canadian SIM card & phone number

Most banks require a local number. Koodo, Public Mobile, and Fido are good prepaid options.

Secure a Canadian address (even temporary)

A letter from a hostel, Airbnb host, or family member is accepted by most banks.

Open a bank account — ask for the newcomer package

TD, RBC, CIBC, Scotiabank all offer 1–2 years free. Bring SIN and passport.

Apply for a credit card on Day 1

Canada runs on credit history. Apply for a secured or newcomer card immediately.

Apply for OHIP (Ontario Health Insurance Plan)

Bring SIN, ID, proof of address. Ontario's 3-month wait has been suspended since 2020.

Get a Presto transit card (Toronto)

Available at any subway station. Cheaper than paying per ride.

Pro tip: Get your SIN first — everything else depends on it. Book a Service Canada appointment online before you arrive.

WEEK 2 · DAYS 8–14

Financial Foundation

Set up direct deposit with your employer

Give your bank's transit number and account number to HR on your first day.

Register with the CRA (Canada Revenue Agency)

Create My Account at canada.ca/my-cra-account. This is where all your benefits are managed.

Apply for the GST/HST credit — file form RC151

Quarterly tax-free payment. RC151 if no children, RC66 if you do. Up to \$533/year for singles.

Set up CRA direct deposit

Link your bank account so benefit payments go directly to you. No waiting for cheques.

Use your credit card weekly — pay it in full

Never miss a payment. This single habit changes your financial life in Canada.

Compare phone plans — switch if needed

Fido, Koodo, and Freedom Mobile offer better rates than Rogers, Bell, and Telus.

Did you know?:

The GST credit, Canada Child Benefit, and worker benefit are yours — but you must apply. Most newcomers miss \$500–\$1,500 in their first year.

WEEKS 3–4 · DAYS 15–30

Healthcare, Housing & Community

Find a family doctor or join a patient waitlist

Search health811.ontario.ca or Health Care Connect. Waitlists are long — register early.

Exchange your foreign driver's license

In Ontario your foreign license is valid for 60 days only. Visit a DriveTest centre with your ID.

Research settlement services in your area

Search 211ontario.ca — free agencies offer employment help, language training, and more.

Register for LINC (Language Instruction for Newcomers)

Free English and French classes funded by the government. Available online and in person.

Understand your lease and renter's rights

Ontario's Residential Tenancies Act protects you. Landlords cannot raise rent beyond the annual guideline.

Download ServiceOntario & Service Canada apps

Manage government services, update your address, and track applications from your phone.

Important:

211ontario.ca lists every free service in your area by postal code. It's one of the most underused resources for newcomers.